population was also correlated and therefore any aspersions that the Government was fudging figures were totally misplaced and incorrect. By the middle of March 2021, when the first wave was waning and inoculations were about to commence, the daily infection rate for the whole Army had come down to single digits. In one of the morning updates, the DGMO suggested that, in view of the improved situation, we could dispense with the Covid Sitrep. I replied that we would do so when the daily figure became zero for one week continuously.

I must have been prescient because, within a week of that, the second wave hit the country like a tsunami. At the height of the first wave, our total daily cases had been in the range of fifty to sixty, which suddenly jumped to 350 to 400 cases a day, even within our garrisons. A sixfold increase, which took us by surprise despite the facilities we had created. Medical resources which were just stabilizing from the first wave were swamped and stretched to the limit. These six to eight weeks of April and May 2021 were the worst. We could barely look after our serving and retired personnel and were inundated with calls from friends and relatives imploring us to do something. We tried to help out as much as we could. In the throes of panic, many people were rushing to the metros, when facilities closer at hand were available. In our case, for example, we diverted many cases to the satellite military stations—Meerut, Agra, Ambala, Dehradun, etc., till these too got full. It was heart-wrenching to see so many tragedies unfold. Through it all, our medical fraternity, doctors, nurses and ancillary staff stood steady as rocks and continued to discharge their duties even while facing tragedies of their own. I made sure that their services were recognized, requesting the RM for additional quotas for distinguished service awards so that we could honour our Covid warriors.

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